

Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, students will be able to:

1. Describe the attitudes of Canadians towards sexual orientation.
2. Recognize the major obstacles faced by gay, lesbian, and bisexual youth and adults.
3. Identify and describe the six stages of gay, lesbian, and bisexual identity development.
4. Identify and describe the four dimensions of the coming out process.

Topic Overview

In terms of the social context of human sexuality, the evolution of societal attitudes and public policies and laws related to sexual orientation represents a fundamental shift in basic assumptions about the very nature of human sexuality and in values concerning what is, and what is not, morally acceptable sexual behaviour.

Sexual Orientation: Notes About Terminology and Acronyms

Some terms related to sexuality can become, over time, politicized. Homosexuality is one of those terms. According to Cornelson (1998) "The term 'homosexual' has a clinical connotation that is associated with pathology and reflects historical judgements that same-sex orientation was an illness. It is thus thought by many to be outdated, inaccurate, and even pejorative" (p. 262). However, the term "homosexuality" is still used in the sexological literature (For example, your textbook uses this term but in a strictly non-pejorative sense.) Most people with same-sex attraction refer to themselves as "gay", "lesbian", or "bisexual", rather than as a "homosexual." For the purposes of this course, the term "homosexual" is used in a value-neutral way that simply defines "homosexuality" as a sexual attraction to another person of the same gender.

Various different acronyms have been used to describe the range of sexual orientations and gender identities that exist. Your textbook chapters on sexual orientation and gender define and discuss many of these identities. Here is an acronym currently used to define different sexually related identities.

LGBTQI2SNA+: Lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, queer, intersex, Two Spirit, nonbinary, asexual and other emerging identities (SIECCAN, 2019). We will use the LGBTQI2SNA+ acronym at various points in the course.

In Module #1 we contrasted the Restrictive and Permissive sexual ideologies. As we saw, according to Restrictive sexual ideology homosexual behaviour should be discouraged, whereas Permissive sexual ideology holds that sexual behaviours should not be judged on the basis of the gender of the partners

involved in a sexual act but rather on the basis of criteria such as whether the behaviour is consensual and mutually beneficial. On these grounds, Permissive sexual ideology holds that homosexual behaviours can have the same moral validity as heterosexual behaviours and that a person's sexual orientation is not in any way an indication of their psychological health. Increasingly, Canadian society is adopting a Permissive sexual ideology towards sexual orientation.

Key Point

Increasingly, Canadian society is adopting a Permissive sexual ideology towards sexual orientation.

Below are the results of a surveys administered in 1975, 1995/96, 2006, and 2013 that measured adult Canadian's attitudes towards homosexuality (Bibby, 1995; 2006; Pew Research, 2014). Research on Canadians attitudes towards sexual orientation is revealing in a number of important ways:

1. The results reflect the trend, over time, towards a more permissive ideological perspective towards homosexuality among Canadians. For example, in 1975, 72% of adult Canadians believed that "homosexual relations" were "Almost always wrong" or "Always wrong". By 1995/96 the percentage of Canadians with this opinion had shrunk to 52%. In addition, the percentage of Canadians who felt that "homosexual relations" were "Not wrong at all" more than doubled from 14% in 1975 to 32% in 1995/96. When Bibby surveyed Canadians a third time a decade later he found that about two-thirds generally approved of homosexuality (Bibby, 2006, cited in Hyde, Delameter & Byers, 2009). In 2013, Pew Research (2014) asked Canadians: "Do you believe that homosexuality is morally unacceptable, morally acceptable, or it is not a moral issue?" Only 15% responded that is unacceptable while 30% said acceptable, 50% responded that it is not a moral issue, and 5% did not respond.
2. Although the data from these studies suggests that Canadians are becoming more accepting of homosexuality over time, the Canadian population remains segmented in its attitudes towards the moral acceptability of homosexual behaviour. Langstaff (2011) reviewed the evolution of Canadians attitudes towards homosexuality and found that although Canadian attitudes have become more accepting overall, much of the shift is the result of people who were more or less neutral about homosexuality shifting their views towards greater acceptance. From her analysis of the survey data, Langstaff concludes that people who have opposed homosexuality in the past have not changed their minds. Indeed, many of these people have become more firm in their disapproval of homosexuality. According to Langstaff, although the percentage of Canadians who are accepting of homosexuality has increased, "...a fairly stable minority of about one-third of Canadians are profoundly dismayed by growing societal acceptance of homosexuality" (p. 59). However, as the Pew Research (2014) survey results, cited above, suggest, the percentage of Canadians who disapprove of gay, lesbian, and bisexual orientations is continuing to shrink. However, many people in Canada, are not fully accepting of diverse sexual orientations (IPSOS, 2021). <https://www.ipsos.com/en-ca/news-polls/global-survey-points-to-increasingly-positive-attitudes-in-canada-toward-lgbt-individuals>

"Whether or not one morally approves or disapproves of homosexual behaviour is immaterial to the principle inherent within a democratic society that all people, irrespective of their sexual orientation or other such characteristic, have the inalienable right to live a life free of discrimination" (*McKay, 1998, p. 160*).

Key Point

Over time, Canadian's attitudes towards diverse sexual orientations are becoming more accepting.

While societal attitudes towards diverse sexual orientations are becoming more accepting, LGBTQI2SNA+ people live in a world where social and cultural conventions are overwhelmingly heterosexual and where their sexual orientation or gender identity is still often viewed with stigma and prejudice. Cultural representations in the media (e.g., advertising, entertainment) have, at least until very recently, been almost entirely heterosexual in nature. Some religious institutions continue to disapprove of homosexuality. Sexuality education programs in the schools may be taught with the assumption that all the students in the class are heterosexual. Many gays, lesbians, and bisexuals have been the victims of violence that resulted from their being targeted because of their sexual orientation. Although all credible mental health professionals now consider homosexuality to be a normal variation of human sexuality, it should be noted that until quite recently, homosexuality was officially considered a mental illness or psychological disorder. For example, it was not until 1973 that the American Psychiatric Association removed homosexuality from its list of psychological disorders. It is in this heterosexually oriented social context that LGBTQI2SNA+ people form their personal identity as human beings.

Key Point

LGBTQI2SNA+ people grow up and achieve developmental tasks in a social environment where their sexuality or gender identity is often viewed with stigma and prejudice.

Gay, Lesbian, Bisexual Developmental Tasks

It is very important that we do not generalize about diverse sexual orientations and gender identities, treating them as if they were all

the same. Each LGBTQI2SNA+ identity is unique. Here, we will focus specifically on the developmental tasks of people who identify as gay, lesbian, or bisexual. Being transgender refers to person's gender identity (e.g., woman, man, or non-binary: see Module 4). In Module 4, identity development among transgender people is discussed.

It's also important that we recognize that a person's identity as gay, lesbian, bisexual, or transgender is just one component of identity and that it will overlap or intersect with other identities a person may have. An intersectional approach considers how different identities simultaneously affect an individual's experiences. An intersectional approach also recognizes that the discrimination and oppression that a person experiences based on sexual orientation may also intersect with other forms of oppression such as those based on race, class, sex, and gender identity.

Challenges Facing Gay, Lesbian, Bisexual Youth

As we proceed through this course we will be looking at the developmental tasks related to sexuality at the various phases of the life span (i.e., childhood, adolescence, adulthood, late adulthood). Gay, lesbian, and bisexual people must also face a series of challenges related to sexuality that heterosexual people do not face. This may particularly be the case for gay, lesbian, and bisexual adolescents who must navigate a heteronormative and often homophobic social world. These challenges are clearly apparent in a survey of youth's experiences of homophobia, biphobia, and transphobia in Canadian schools (Peter et al., 2021: <https://egale.ca/awareness/still-in-every-class/>). For example, according to the Peter et al. (2021) survey, 64% of students reported hearing homophobic comments at school and 30% of 2SLGBTQ students reported that they had been the victims of cyber bullying.

For many gay, lesbian and bisexual people, their sexual orientation is a major defining characteristic of who they are as people. We will be looking at two fundamental aspects of personal and social development for gays, lesbians and bisexuals: stages of identity development and the dimensions of coming out.

The term "coming out" is commonly thought of as the process of informing other people that one is gay, lesbian or bisexual. However, in reality, the process of coming out entails much more than simply telling other people about your sexual orientation.

Key Point

The coming out process involves much more than disclosure to others.

According to Rosario, Hunter, Maguen, Gwadz and Smith (2001) the process of coming out involves four dimensions (see below). It is only with the fourth dimension that the person discloses to others that they are gay, lesbian, or bisexual. In a similar way, the individual's development of a gay, lesbian, or bisexual identity is not a single step process but rather involves a series of stages.

Listed below are stages of gay, lesbian, and bisexual identity development and the dimensions of the coming out process. You will notice that in many ways the stages of identity development and the dimensions of the coming out process are parallel to each other. That is, for example, identity comparison, the second stage of identity development in which a person begins to understand that they are gay, lesbian, or bisexual and the first dimension of the coming out process, self-identification of sexual orientation are basically describing the same process: discovering feelings of same sex attraction.

The important distinction we need to make is that the stages of identity development are focused on the person's internal **psychological development** whereas the dimensions of the coming out process are describing key factors of the person's **social development** as a gay, lesbian or bisexual person. For example, the stage of identity acceptance refers to the individual's acceptance in their own mind that they are in fact gay, lesbian or bisexual whereas, for example, the dimension of becoming involved in gay/lesbian activities refers to the individual's social interaction with others. Together, the stages of identity development and the stages of coming out provide a basic conceptualization of the developmental tasks related to sexual orientation for gay, lesbian and bisexual people.

It is also important to recognize that these processes of identity development and coming out occur within, and are a reflection of, the **heteronormativity** of our society. Heteronormativity is the assumption or belief that heterosexuality is the default, or "normal" form of sexual expression. It is within this heteronormative context that gay, lesbian, and bisexual people form their identity. As a result, we should not look upon these stages of identity development and dimensions of coming out as points along the road of ideal development but rather as points of struggle and progression that gay, lesbian, and bisexual people must face because of the heteronormativity of society. As heteronormativity fades as society progresses, these stages of identity development and dimensions of coming out will become less relevant.

Key Point

The stages of identity development relate to a person's internal psychological development. The dimensions of coming out relate to a person's social development. Both occur within, and are a reflection of, the heteronormativity of Western culture.

Stages of Identity Development (Cass, 1984)

1. Identity Confusion

The person, usually in childhood, growing up in a heteronormative society, assumes they are heterosexual but has some feelings of same gender attraction.

2. Identity Comparison

The person begins to recognize that they may be gay, lesbian, or bisexual.

3. Identity Tolerance

The person more fully recognizes that that it is likely that they are in fact gay, lesbian or bisexual and may seek out contact with others in the gay, lesbian, and bisexual communities to find affirmation.

4. Identity Acceptance

The person now fully recognizes that they are gay, lesbian, or bisexual and accepts their sexual orientation.

5. Identity Pride

The person begins to accept their sexual orientation as a positive aspect of themselves and contrasts and differentiate themselves from heterosexuals.

6. Identity Synthesis

The individual focuses on fully integrating their public and private identities as gay, lesbian, or bisexual.

Dimensions of the Coming Out Process (Rosario, Hunter, Maguen, Gwadz & Smith, 2001)

1. Self-identification as gay, lesbian, or bisexual
2. Involvement in gay/lesbian recreational and social activities
3. Attitudes towards GLB identities become more positive
4. Disclosure of sexual identity to others

"The coming out process is an individual experience. The milestones, the hurdles and the pace of the process, all vary from person to person. Individuals bring a variety of coping skills, problem-solving abilities and resources to the process" (*Schneider, 1988, p. 50*).

It is important to recognize that although the stages of identity development have been presented in a step by step linear fashion (i.e., in a 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6 progression), many gay, lesbian, and bisexual people will not necessarily pass through all of these stages in the same order. For example, some individuals may not develop social links with the gay, lesbian, or bisexual communities until well after all the other stages have been completed. In terms of identity development, because they live in an often homophobic culture (see Chapter 9 of your textbook for a definition and discussion of homophobia), some gays, lesbians, and bisexuals struggle with the coming out process. Also, research shows that the

timing and progression of the coming out process can be affected by intersectional factors such as gender, race, ethnicity, class, and generational factors (Groß, Bimbi, Nanin, & Parsons, 2006; Haltom & Ratcliff, 2021). <https://link-springer-com.ezproxy.lib.torontomu.ca/content/pdf/10.1007/s10508-020-01776-x>

It is important to note that some people are quite critical of fixed stage models of gay, lesbian, and bisexual identity development. For example, Alderson (2013) believes that identity development is a highly individualized process that is affected by a wide range of factors. Not everyone goes through the same stages in the same order. However, acknowledging individual variations in processes and trajectories, stage models can be useful in understanding developmental processes of LGBTQ+ young people (McInroy et al., 2021). A meta analysis of 30 studies indicated that common sequence of LGB+ identity development was becoming aware of queer attractions, questioning one's sexual orientation, self-identifying as LGB+, coming out to others, engaging in sexual activity, and starting a romantic relationship (Hall et al., 2021). <https://www.frontiersin.org/journals/psychology/articles/10.3389/fpsyg.2021.753954/full>

Key Point

Not all individuals will progress through the stages of identity development in a step-by-step linear fashion.

Although the stages of identity development and the dimensions of the coming out described above do not apply to everyone, they can be useful concepts for health professionals addressing the needs of gay, lesbian, and bisexual students and clients. For example, assessing the stage a person is at in terms of their identity and social development can be helpful in determining specific issues that need to be addressed and to determine if a client is making progress in their development. Discussing the stages with clients can help them to make a self-determination of where they are at and where they want to go next in terms of their personal development.

There are a number of ways that the school system and educators can promote the health and well-being of LGBTQ students. These include developing school policies that create supportive environments, teacher and school staff training programs, developing and implementing LGBTQ inclusive school curricula, and fostering the development of LGBTQ student clubs, organizations, and alliances (Russell et al., 2021).

Key Point

Although they don't apply to everyone, the stages of identity development and the dimensions of the coming out process can be useful concepts for health professionals to consider in working with gay, lesbian, and bisexual clients.

In the next five modules we will continue with the approach of using developmental tasks to examine sexuality in childhood, adolescence, adulthood, and late adulthood.

Review Poll 2

Module 5 - Due by the end of this week of study.

Complete the four multiple choice questions below. Then click on Activity below to receive your short answer response question and follow the instructions on how to submit your short answer response. Alex will provide a commentary on the poll responses and short answers on the Review Poll 2 discussion board. To begin please click on the Review Poll links below.

Question A2 - Module 4 describes the traditional sexual script for sexual interactions and gender roles. To what extent do you agree that the traditional sexual script contributes to gender inequality?

- ☐ Strongly agree
- ☐ Agree
- ☐ Neutral
- ☐ Disagree
- ☐ Strongly disagree

Submit

Question B2 - The research on gender and sexuality tends to highlight differences between genders (e.g., people who identify as women or men). But are people with different gender identities really that different? In general, do you believe that

when it comes to basic sexual priorities, needs, and desires, women and men are:

- ☐ Very different
- ☐ Somewhat different
- ☐ Not different at all

Submit

Question C2 - As discussed in the textbook, there are theories and research that seek to explain the development of sexual orientation. Some people believe that this kind of research helps to dispel harmful myths and misconceptions and will contribute to full equality in society with respect to sexual orientation. Other people believe that research on the biological or social origins of sexual orientation is not useful and potentially dangerous. To what extent do you agree that researchers should be discouraged from investigating the origins of sexual orientation?

Question C2-To what extent do you agree that researchers should be discouraged from attempting to identify the determinants of sexual orientation?

- ☐ Strongly agree
- ☐ Agree
- ☐ Neutral
- ☐ Disagree
- ☐ Strongly disagree

Submit

Question D2 - There has been disagreement in the province of Ontario about the grade level that children should first be taught about the diversity of sexual orientations and gender

identities. At what Grade level do you think these topics should be introduced?

- ☐ K to 3
- ☐ 4 to 5
- ☐ 6 to 7
- ☐ 8 or later

Submit

Activity

[Click here to get an Assignment based on the Opinion Polls above.](#)

Please Note

You can revisit the review poll to view the updated results of your classmates' opinions.

References

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- SIECCAN. (2019). *Canadian Guidelines for Sexual Health Education*. Toronto, ON: Sex Information and Education Council of Canada. <http://sieccan.org/>

Readings

Reading

Required Reading

Human Sexuality in a World of Diversity 7th Canadian Edition, Chapter 9.

Reading for Further Research/Essay Assignments

Grov, C., Bimbi, D., Nanin, J., & Parsons, J. (2006). Race, ethnicity, gender, and generational factors associated with the coming-out process among gay, lesbian, and bisexual individuals. *The Journal of Sex Research*, 43 (2), 115-121.

Hall, W. J., Dawes, H. C., & Plocek, N. (2021). Sexual orientation identity development milestones among lesbian, gay, bisexual, and queer people: A systematic review and meta-analysis. *Frontiers in psychology*, 12, 753954.

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